

Chemotherapy for advanced melanoma

Chemotherapy uses anti-cancer drugs to destroy cancer cells. It is sometimes used to help control or slow the growth of advanced melanoma.

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What is chemotherapy?

[Chemotherapy](#) is the use of anti-cancer (cytotoxic) drugs to destroy cancer cells. It is not often used to treat melanoma. Your doctor may recommend having chemotherapy, if [immunotherapy](#) and [targeted therapies](#) are no longer working for you.

Chemotherapy may help control or slow the growth of [advanced melanoma](#) for a time. Your cancer doctor and specialist nurse will explain more about the [possible benefits and side effects](#).

There are different [chemotherapy drugs](#) that may be used to treat advanced melanoma. They include:

- [dacarbazine](#) (DTIC)
- [temozolomide](#)
- [carboplatin](#).

You may have only 1 drug, or a combination.

Having chemotherapy for advanced melanoma

You usually have chemotherapy drugs as an injection into a vein (intravenously), or sometimes by mouth (orally). Chemotherapy is often given as an outpatient. This means you can go home on the same day.

Side effects of chemotherapy

Chemotherapy drugs may cause unpleasant side effects. Side effects can usually be well controlled with medicines. They usually go away once treatment has finished. Your doctor and nurse will tell you about the likely side effects and how they can be managed.

We have more information about the [side effects of chemotherapy](#).

Other ways of giving chemotherapy

Sometimes chemotherapy for melanoma is given in other ways.

Electrochemotherapy

[Electrochemotherapy](#) uses chemotherapy and a small electrical current to destroy cancer cells. It may be used to treat some melanoma tumours of the skin to help control symptoms.

Chemotherapy into an arm or leg

Chemotherapy can be given [directly into a limb](#). This is called regional chemotherapy. It can be used to treat clusters of melanomas that have come back on the same limb.

About our information

References

Below is a sample of the sources used in our advanced melanoma information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at cancerinformationteam@macmillan.org.uk

Keilholz U, Ascierto PA, Dummer R, et al. ESMO consensus conference recommendations on the management of metastatic melanoma: under the auspices of the ESMO Guidelines Committee. *Annals of Oncology*. 2020. 31 (11): 1435-1448 [accessed May 2022].

Peach H, Board R, Cook M, et al. Current role of sentinel lymph node biopsy in the management of cutaneous melanoma: A UK consensus statement. *Journal of Plastic, Reconstructive & Aesthetic Surgery*. 2020; 73, 1, 36-42 [accessed May 2022].

Reviewers



This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer. It has been approved by Senior Medical Editor, Professor Samra Turajlic, Consultant Medical Oncologist.

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Our cancer information has been awarded the [PIF TICK](#). Created by the Patient Information Forum, this quality mark shows we meet PIF's 10 criteria for trustworthy health information.

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 October 2022 | Next review: 01 October 2025

⚠ This content is currently being reviewed. New information will be coming soon.

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help